facilities for repair. It was imperative therefore that SSNCo have a branch in Bombay. Once again, we do not know when the Bombay branch opened but it was early, possibly immediately after the registration of the company. By April 1907, the branch was operating from 1, Green Street, Fort.[27] The branch liaised with shipping agents and shipping companies as SSNCo went about the task of purchasing steamers. With VOC in Bombay for many months from late 1906, this branch was vital to the overall scheme of things. Soonderdas Dhurumsey & Co. was the company's Agent at Bombay. This firm provided brokerage services for SSNCo for buying the steamers.

In January 1907, VOC opened the Madras branch office at 42, Mannady Street, Georgetown, just across the harbour. The office was situated 'in a small room upstairs of … a common eating house'.[28] A young Brahmin, W. Srinivasan, was appointed the general agent of the Madras branch (this was most certainly the W. Srinivasa Iyengar who became a director of the company in September 1907[29]). Srinivasan had four sub-agents working under him: M.G. Punt (possibly from the trading caste of Bunts from coastal Karnataka), P. Somasundaram Pillai, M. Krishnaswamy Mudaliar and R.S. Somasundara Aiyar.[30] It is not clear what actual shipping business SSNCo had in Madras. Perhaps the branch acted more as an office to coordinate matters in the presidency capital, and as a centre for selling shares. In any case, between the agents mentioned above they managed to canvas about 400 shares within months.[31] The Madras police reported that one R.S. Sundaram Aiyar (possibly the same R.S. Somasundara Aiyar mentioned above) was paid Rs 20 per month for canvassing shares; with the help of one T. Ramaswami Mudaliar—described by the police as 'another obscure person'—he also organized public meetings for this purpose.[32] Clearly, ordinary people who were not on the police radar were getting involved in Swadeshi work.

We do not know when the Calcutta branch was opened but an advertisement in *Bande Mataram*, in April 1907, gives its address as 34, Phears Lane, Bowbazar.[33] Calcutta was not only the headquarters of BI, but was also the epicentre of the Swadeshi movement. Though we know